



1. Ideas

This relates to all the learning that takes place leading up to a writing task.

- *What do you want the students to write about?*
- *What knowledge or understandings do you want students to demonstrate through their writing?*
- *What big ideas or issues do you want them to explore?*

By and large, this is something that teachers naturally do well, and teaching ideas tends to make up the bulk of our classroom instruction time. We read books, web pages and chapters from textbooks; we watch videos and have discussions.

Examples of ideas in practice:

Science	Students explain the effect of friction on motion on a variety of surfaces.
History	Students write a conversation between an Athenian woman and a Spartan woman where they describe their different lifestyles.
Maths	Students write an interpretation of data presented in a graph.
Art	Students write an analysis of the use of line and texture in an artwork.
Health	Students write a summary that synthesises information on mental health from three different sources.
English	Students write a narrative scene based on the characters from <i>The Bone Sparrow</i> .

"I don't know what to write!"

But what happens when students are stuck? How many times have we encountered a student who struggles to get started without being told what to write?

For each of the six traits, this guide will include two elements to help support your students:

1. **Common language**

Words and ideas that should be used in the same way across all learning areas.*

2. **Suggestions for differentiated scaffolds**

A series of ideas that could be incorporated at each stage in the writing process.

** Subject-specific definitions of certain key and command terms notwithstanding.*

Common language

To begin, it is imperative that we have a shared vocabulary that relates to the ideas contained in students' writing.

Low-stakes writing	Unstructured writing that allows students to explore and experiment with ideas. Low-stakes writing is not for assessment, but a student's private writing.
Contention	The overall idea presented in a persuasive or analytic text.
Intention	The effect or impact the writer hopes to achieve by writing a text.
Argument	A series of claims that lead to a conclusion/prove a contention.
Claim	A statement that is presented as true, usually supported by evidence.

Analytic writing:

The following is a suggested progression that synthesises ideas from [Bloom](#), [SOLO](#) and the [VCAA's glossary of command terms](#).

Identify	Name or point to an idea or element. In Bloom's, the student is at the "remember" stage. Under SOLO, the student is at a unistuctural stage. <i>The artwork contains pointillism and hatchwork.</i>
Describe	Write about how the idea or element appears. In Bloom's, the student is at the beginning of the "understand" stage, and in SOLO, they are either "unistructural" "multistructural", depending on the number of elements described. <i>The street has some walkability hazards, such as an uneven footpath and lack of a pedestrian crossing.</i>
Explain	Write about the cause and effect of an idea or element. This is at the higher end of "understand" and "multistructural". <i>In the 6th Century, long periods of droughts and low flood waters along the Nile led to a lack of faith in the God-King and the eventual fall of the Old Kingdom.</i>
Analyse	Write about the way multiple ideas or elements interact with each other in a given context. The Bloom's stage is also called "Analyse", while the relative SOLO stage is "Relational". <i>The clockwork rhythms of the "fat gold watch" are further signified by the steadily repeated single-stress syllables, suggesting that the importance of the mother's biological clock has been surpassed by the beginning of a new life.</i>

Scaffolding students' ideas

There are many things that we already do in our classrooms to support students at this stage of writing.

- Discussing ideas
- [Brainstorms, mind maps, visual thinking organisers](#)
- Have students complete short-answer exercises
- Reading from a range of information sources
- Viewing and doing
- Low-stakes writing tasks

See Think Wonder		
 SEE What do you see?	 THINK What do you think is going on?	 WONDER What does it make you wonder?

Adapted by Alice Rogers 2017

Y-chart

